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VOXT

THE ASTRAL HEIR. BOOK ONE.

VOXT

THE ASTRAL HEIR

Book One of The Voxt Chronicles

A Superhero Fantasy Science-Fiction Novel

Written by

Jason

For the ones who felt the stars calling before they knew why.

And for the painters.

The ones who see what the rest of the world has not yet learned to look at.

SYNOPSIS

For centuries, Earth believed itself alone in the universe. It was wrong.

Beyond the farthest edge of known space exists a divine system of four worlds bound together by celestial rings around an eternal cosmic orb known as the VAYRUNE CORE — a living star inhabited by two ancient energy emperors, Oryth and Vexul, worshipped across four planets as gods. These Soul Emperors searched creation for a single bloodline worthy enough to host their combined power and serve as protector of both Earth and the stars. They made agreements with Earth's greatest mystical entities, and together they chose one man to be the first host.

That bloodline became VOXT.

Ten generations of warriors inherited the mantle before the eleventh arrived.

The lineage is ancient and storied. Its greatest chapter belongs to Lady Nyxora — the Fourth Voxt, the most powerful in history — whose four great-grandsons became the Fifth, Sixth, Seventh, and Eighth Voxts simultaneously, an event without precedent in the bloodline's record. Of those four brothers, only one continued the line. His great-grandson, King Thaerion Veyrin, became the Tenth Voxt.

And now the eleventh has arrived.

Kael Veyrin is an ordinary young painter living in Midway City, haunted by dreams of glowing statues, collapsing planets, and voices calling his name from somewhere beyond the stars. He has always felt like something in his life does not fit — like a painting whose colors are right but whose composition belongs to a different canvas entirely.

He is about to find out why.

When a brutal attack reveals that Kael is not the human he believed himself to be, a powerful alien military guardian named Seraphyne Valoris delivers the truth: he is the heir to the Voxt bloodline, the son of a living king who believed his son was dead, and the fulfillment of a prophecy left centuries ago by the greatest Voxt who ever lived.

Now war is returning to the ancient world of AETHERION. The Three Siblings — ancient conquerors defeated a generation ago — have returned with an army of soul-infected soldiers. And behind them moves the oldest darkness of all: the Crimson Soul King, Malzareth, who has been patient as death.

Kael must uncover the history of his bloodline, find his father across the stars, and unlock the forbidden Voxt State — a transformation that calls the spirits of every Voxt before him to float at his side and multiply his power beyond imagination. He will discover that being a Voxt is not about power. It is about seeing clearly what others refuse to look at — and having the courage to carry it.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Prologue: The Stars Screamed

PART ONE: THE PAINTER OF EARTH

Chapter 1: The Boy Who Painted Stars

Chapter 2: The Eyes in the Mirror

Chapter 3: The Woman in Black Armor

Chapter 4: The Night Midway Burned

Chapter 5: Voices from the Orb

Chapter 6: The Guardian's Secret

PART TWO: AETHERION

Chapter 7: Through the Ring Gate

Chapter 8: The Four Worlds

Chapter 9: The Statues of the Fallen

Chapter 10: The Throne of Stone

Chapter 11: The Father Who Survived

Chapter 12: The Prophecy of Nyxora

Chapter 13: The Crimson Infection

Chapter 14: The Council Wars

PART THREE: THE RETURN OF DARKNESS

Chapter 15: The Three Siblings Return

Chapter 16: Fall of Theronis

Chapter 17: The Breaking of the Rings

Chapter 18: The Death March

Chapter 19: The Last Shrine

Chapter 20: The Awakening of Vox

Chapter 21: Father and Son

Chapter 22: The Soul War

Chapter 23: The Green and Violet Storm

Chapter 24: The Final Stand

Epilogue: The Hero of Earth

PROLOGUE

The Stars Screamed



The stars screamed.

Across the endless darkness between galaxies, four worlds trembled beneath a storm of green and violet lightning. Celestial rings of forged cosmic energy connecting the planets burned like rivers of fire across the heavens, their light visible from ten solar systems in any direction. The sky of each world turned a deep, turbulent bruise of color that was partly beautiful and mostly terrible.

At the center of all four planets, the Vayrune Core awakened.

Not in the way that sleeping things wake. It woke the way a fire wakes when given air — suddenly, completely, without negotiation. Its light spread outward through the celestial rings, through the roots of each planet's core, through the nervous system of the entire Aetherion system. Ancient kings on all four worlds fell to their knees simultaneously, not knowing why, only knowing that something vast and fundamental had shifted.

Inside the living orb, two colossal beings of pure energy regarded the universe unfolding below them.

Oryth. Vexul.

The Soul Emperors. The Green and the Violet. Who had inhabited the Vayrune Core since before the four planets finished cooling. Who had guided the creation of the Vext

bloodline across ten generations and now watched with the stillness of beings who have seen enough of time to know when something irreversible is happening.

"The balance weakens," said Oryth. His voice was the color green given form — living, surging.

"Then the eleventh heir must rise," answered Vexul. Her voice was the color violet given depth — considered, sacrificial.

Below them, armies burned.

Cities on Theronis collapsed inward as red-lit figures moved through them with the unified, terrible purpose of things that no longer had their own will. On Lyxara, the great spirit temples went dark one by one. On Drakorum, the weapons forges fell silent. And on Elysiar, the royal seat of all four worlds, chaos erupted as reports came in from every direction.

The Siblings had returned.

Vorakh. Sylthera. Kaedros.

Three ancient conquerors who had been defeated a generation ago and who had spent that generation rebuilding with the patience that only beings who have already died once truly possess.

At the edge of the last burning field on Elysiar stood a single warrior.

His black-and-green armor was shattered at the shoulder. Blood covered the left side of his face. One arm hung at an angle that suggested something broken. And yet his eyes — blazing with the green and violet fire of the Vox power — still burned. Light that refuses to go out not because it cannot be extinguished but because it has decided not to be.

King Thaerion Veyrin. The Tenth Vext. Father. Warrior. A man carrying more than any one person should carry, still standing.

In his arms he carried a child.

The infant was weeks old. His eyes, closed in sleep despite the chaos, showed at their inner corners the faintest suggestion of a glow. Green. Like something waiting.

Behind Thaerion, Seraphyne Valoris knelt beside the queen.

Queen Lyrielle Veyrin had been the most formidable strategic mind in three generations of Elysiar's royal history. Even now, with her light going, she was still performing calculations. She looked at the child in Thaerion's arms and the calculation had one answer, and the answer was not what either of them wanted.

"Take him to Earth," she whispered. "If he stays, they will find him. If they find him, they will kill him. Or worse." She meant the soul-infection. The Crimson King's reach. A child whose blood carried this much power was the most dangerous kind of target.

A massive explosion detonated three hundred meters to the east. The sky above Elysiar turned completely red.

Three figures watched from a ridge above the valley. Vorakh, his hands trailing smoke from destruction magic. Sylthera, whose eyes moved with the quality of someone reading a room she had already rearranged. Kaedros, who had once been something other than what he was now, wearing the evidence of that change in the forward, resigned posture of a man who has stopped arguing with himself.

Lyrielle reached up and placed her hand against her son's forehead. A slow wash of green light moved from her palm across his skin — the last message a lighthouse sends before the storm takes it.

"My son," she whispered. "One day you will become more powerful than all of us."

She looked at Thaerion one last time.

Her hand fell.

The queen died.

Thaerion's grief was the kind that has no sound — too large for any vocalization. The Vayrune Core felt it. Across all four planets the celestial rings dimmed for a single pulse. Then the Core blazed: the heavens turned completely green, the most vivid and consuming green any soul on any of the four worlds had ever witnessed, and then it faded, and the dark came back.

Seraphyne was already moving.

"The portal," she said. A fact she was making true by stating it.

She opened it.

Beyond the portal: a blue-green world at the far edge of an unremarkable solar system. A world that would keep one small child safe for as long as safety was possible.

Thaerion looked at his son. He memorized the face. The weight of him. The faint warmth of the green glow at his eyes. He kissed the child's forehead and handed him to Seraphyne.

"Keep him alive," said the king.

"With my life," said Seraphyne.

She stepped through the portal. It closed.

Thaerion turned back to the field, his broken arm no obstacle, his grief no obstacle. He rose into the air — the Vixt State igniting, eyes blazing green-violet, his body lifting

several meters off the burning ground — and flew toward the Three Siblings alone, buying time the way only someone with nothing left to lose except a future they cannot see can buy it.

Earth waited on the other side of the portal.

The child slept.

And the legend of the final Voxt began.

PART ONE

The Painter of Earth

CHAPTER ONE

The Boy Who Painted Stars

Midway City — Present Day



The canvas was doing it again.

Kael Veyrin had been awake since two in the morning — not insomnia exactly, more like the specific state of being called awake by something he could not name. He had given up on sleep at two-fifteen and gone to his easel. This happened three or four times a week. He had long since stopped questioning it and simply set an alarm for six AM and painted until it went off.

What he had not stopped questioning was the paintings themselves.

The one on the easel right now had started as a night sky study. He had meant to paint the view from his window: the city lights of Midway City spreading to the horizon, the familiar geometry of the skyline he had been looking at for four years. That was what he had intended.

What he had painted instead was this: four enormous planets arranged in a loose square in a deep-space sky, connected at their equators by rings of luminous energy that pulsed like veins. At the center of their arrangement, an orb — not a sun, not shaped like a star, but a sphere, massive, turbulent on its surface, colored in two energies that wound around each other without ever fully mixing: green and violet. And in the sky around the orb, barely visible, a trail of emerald light streaking upward — a figure, flying, trailing power behind them like a comet.

He had not decided to paint any of this. He had simply painted, and this was what came out.

It was the eleventh time in two months that his paintings had gone somewhere he had not sent them.

He set down his brush and looked at his hands. The knuckles of his right hand — his painting hand — were warm. And at the joints, very faintly, a glow that you would dismiss as a trick of the lamp if you only saw it once. He had seen it many times. He had stopped dismissing it.

Kael Veyrin was twenty-two years old and he was a painter. He lived in a studio apartment in the Caldwell District of Midway City, in a building whose super was named Holt. He had grown up in this city — in the foster system for the first six years, then with David and Vera, his adoptive parents, who had chosen him and raised him with the warmth of people who build their family deliberately. He had one close friend, Davan Cross, who painted enormous abstract pieces in colors so aggressive they seemed to be making a personal argument. He had a paint-stained jacket he wore in all weather. He had a life that was good and his and real.

He just was not sure it was the whole story.

He looked at the flying figure in his painting. The trail of green light. The sense of absolute speed and freedom.

He turned the alarm off before it rang and started a fresh canvas.

Below him, Midway City was beginning to wake up.



He met Davan at their usual spot on the corner of Archer and Fifth — a coffee cart run by a man named Reeves who operated it as though personal grudges against decaf were a form of civic duty.

"You painted last night," Davan said. Not a question.

"Four planets again. But this time there was a figure flying. Green light trailing behind them. Impossibly fast."

Davan sipped his coffee and looked over the rim in the way he had when deciding whether to say the obvious thing. "Eleven paintings, Kael. All from somewhere that is not your conscious decision. And your hands glow."

"A little."

"A little," Davan repeated, neutrally. "At what point do you stop treating this as a creative anomaly and start treating it as information?"

"I don't know what I'd do with the information."

"That is what information is for. Figuring out what to do with it."

Kael thought about the flying figure. The green light. The feeling of two voices just below the range of language, always present, always waiting.

"Something is coming," he said. He said it the way you say something you've known for a while and have been not-saying.

"What makes you think that?"

"Because whatever it is," Kael said, "it already started. I just haven't caught up yet."

CHAPTER TWO

The Eyes in the Mirror



The dreams had been with him for as long as he could remember.

Not nightmares. They were immersive in the way that the most real things are: specific, textured, populated with detail that the dreaming mind does not usually manufacture. In the dreams he walked through cities that were not Earth cities. The architecture was stone and something else — a material that caught light at angles that should not have been possible. The streets were wide and the sky always the wrong color: too deep, too layered, with two moons visible even in daylight and the faint green-violet signature of a vast orb at the system's center.

And he flew in the dreams.

That was the part that had always stayed with him most clearly upon waking — the sensation of rising, of the ground falling away without fear, of his body moving through the air with a speed that was not mechanical but felt innate, as natural as breathing. In the dreams he flew over those impossible cities and looked down at their brushstroke streets and felt completely, entirely himself. More himself than he ever felt on the ground.

The voices came in the dreams too. Two of them. One green, one violet. They did not speak in any language he knew, but he understood the emotional content the way you understand music: this is important. This is coming. You are not what you think you are. Hold on.

Three days after the conversation at the coffee cart, Kael woke from one of the dreams with his hands so warm they had left an impression in the bedsheets. He lay still and looked at the ceiling and waited for the dream to fade.

It did not.

Not fully. It left a fragment behind: a plateau. Stone statues on it — many more than he'd seen in previous dreams. Not seven. More. He walked among them in the fragment and they were warm and they knew him and the last one he came to had her arms extended, palms up, and the look on her face was not of greeting but of recognition. As though she had been expecting him for a very long time.

He got up and went to the bathroom and looked at himself in the mirror.

His eyes were glowing.

Not the knuckles. His eyes. The irises — usually dark brown — were currently suffused with light. Green, predominantly. With at the outermost edge the beginning of violet.

He stared at himself for thirty-seven seconds. He counted.

Then the glow faded back to dark brown.

"Okay," he said to his reflection.

His reflection looked back at him with the expression of someone who has run out of explanations and is about to start looking for different ones.

CHAPTER THREE

The Woman in Black Armor



She had been watching him for four years.

Seraphyne Valoris had arrived in Midway City twenty-two years ago through a portal that deposited her in an alley two blocks from where she now stood, carrying an infant and a cover identity and instructions that amounted to: keep him alive and do not let him know, not yet, not until the danger is at the threshold.

She had kept the instructions.

She was a Commander of the Theronis Planetary Guard — the military world of Aetherion's four planets, world of floating fortresses and sky fleets and training academies where soldiers were formed across a decade that began in childhood and ended only when the student graduated or did not survive graduation. Seraphyne had graduated first in her class three years running and had been assigned to the Voxt's personal guard at twenty-six, which was the greatest honor available to a Theronis soldier.

She was forty-three years old. She had a small scar at the corner of her left eyebrow and the posture of someone trained to treat every environment as a potential operational theater, which on Earth manifested as a quality of seeming slightly more present than anyone else in a room — more immediately aware of every exit.

She had watched Kael grow up from a careful distance. She had been there, invisible, when the foster system handed him to the Veyrins at age six. She had been there through art school, through the paint-stained jacket, through Davan Cross. She had

watched him stand on rooftops at sunset with a sketchbook, leaning into the wind, and she had recognized the posture as one she had seen in Vox training manuals: the unconscious instinct of a body that knew it was built to be above the ground. He just had not been told yet.

And now she was here because the signals had changed.

The dormant Vox power in Kael's bloodline had been activating slowly for two months. What was not expected was the second signal: a Crimson Soul marker, detected forty-eight hours ago. One of Malzareth's trackers, operating on Earth. Following the Vox bloodline's activation signal.

They had found him.

She had forty-eight hours at most.

She moved from her observation position and went to prepare.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Night Midway Burned



It happened at eleven-forty PM on a Tuesday.

Kael was walking back from Davan's studio, taking the longer route along the canal because the city at night from the canal walkway was one of his favorite views — the lights doubling in the water, the towers framed against whatever the sky was doing. The particular quality of Midway City's nighttime silence which was not silence at all but a layered texture of distance-softened sound he had painted seventeen times and never quite gotten right.

He saw them at the corner of Harmon Street and the canal path.

Three of them. Standing with the stillness of people who had found what they were looking for. Their eyes caught the streetlight wrong — a reddish quality in the irises, too uniform, too saturated, the specific color of something that had replaced the natural color rather than being it.

His hands were already warm. Too warm.

The first one reached for him.

What happened next Kael did not fully understand until much later. In the moment it felt like instinct — the same instinct that moves your hand from a flame before you consciously register the heat. He felt the reaching hand come toward him and something in his body responded: a surge of warmth up his arms and outward through his hands, and the energy that hit the attacker did not hit like a blow. It hit the way the

truth hits someone — full-stop, complete — and the man stumbled back four meters and hit the canal railing with an expression of pure bewilderment.

Without thinking, without deciding, Kael felt himself rise.

His feet left the ground. Not dramatically — not shooting upward — but with the quiet inevitability of something returning to its natural state. He hovered perhaps a meter above the canal path, looking down at the three attackers with an expression of complete surprise at himself, his hands blazing green and trailing light at the fingertips like slow-moving smoke.

"What—" he started.

And then Seraphyne was there.

She came from above — already airborne, dropping fast from a height that should have been impossible, armor blazing with the green-violet energy signature that Kael recognized without knowing why. She engaged the attackers with absolute, fluid combat: no wasted motion, no hesitation. As she moved she left brief green circle-constructs in the air behind her hands, rings of solidified energy that intercepted two of the attackers before they could reorient, pinning them against the canal railing.

The third came for Kael.

He was still hovering. His hands were so bright now they cast hard shadows on the canal path below. He looked at the approaching figure — at its true nature, in a way he could not have described but which was happening regardless — and felt the handle of the situation. He extended both hands and pushed, and the energy that came out formed a broad disc of green light, flat and spinning like a thrown plate, and when it hit the attacker it did not hurt him so much as simply stop him completely. The man hung

in the air for a moment like a paused film, suspended in the green field, and then lowered gently to the ground.

Kael blinked at his own hands.

He descended slowly. His feet found the canal path.

Seraphyne was looking at him with what he would come to know as her version of relief: a very slight easing around the eyes.

"We need to go," she said. "Now. There will be more."

"I just flew," he said.

"Yes."

"And made a disc of green light."

"Also yes."

"And you made rings."

"I did." She held out her hand. "I will explain everything. But not here."

He looked at his hands. At the canal. At the three unconscious figures.

He took her hand.

CHAPTER FIVE

Voices from the Orb



They went to a safehouse in the warehouse district — a space Seraphyne had maintained for eleven years, running on a power grid from a source he did not recognize that hummed at a frequency just below audibility.

She told him the shape of it first. A world. A bloodline. An inheritance spanning eleven generations. Two emperor-souls who had searched creation for the right host, made their agreements with Earth's greatest powers, and chosen a man ten generations ago who became the first in a line that now ended — began — with him.

"And I'm the eleventh," he said.

"You are the eleventh Voxt."

He let that settle.

"The powers. What can I actually do?"

She described it: Soul Conjuring — the ability to perceive the fundamental nature of anything and bring it into cooperation with his will, carrying what should be uncarryable, moving what should be immovable. Astral Reinforcement — sharing his energy field with others, making them near-invulnerable while connected. Celestial Forging — constructing weapons, shields, and tools from pure green energy. Spirit Echoes — communication with every prior Voxt through the bloodline's accumulated record.

"And the constructs," she said. "The circular energy forms. Every Voxt uses them differently — some as shields, some as platforms, some as binding rings. They respond to intention. You think what you need and the energy takes the form."

"I made a disc tonight. Without knowing what I was doing."

"You will make much more when you know." She paused. "And you can fly. You felt that tonight. The Voxt body is built for it — the energy that powers everything else also allows you to lift yourself, move at speeds no other being in any of the four systems can match on open air."

"How fast?"

"Fast enough that during the first war, your great ancestor crossed from one side of Theronis to the other in the time it takes to draw a breath."

He sat with that.

"And the Voxt State?" he said. He had heard the phrase in dreams and knew, without knowing how he knew, that it was the most important thing.

"A transformation. When you enter it, every Voxt before you merges with your consciousness. Their spirits — all ten of them — emerge from your body and float around you, visible to anyone who is watching. Their power channels through you. It multiplies everything." She met his eyes. "And when you call it, you will know the words. Every Voxt has known them. They are not taught. They are inherited."

"What are they?"

"By the power of Voxt," she said simply.

The words landed in him like a key into a lock he had been carrying for twenty-two years.

"My parents."

"Your mother was Queen Lyrielle Veyrin of Elysiar," Seraphyne said. "She died the night I brought you here. The last thing she did was place her hand on your forehead and give you her blessing." She paused. "I was there."

"And my father."

"Thaerion Veyrin. King of Elysiar. The Tenth Voxt." She looked at him directly. "He is alive. He has been fighting across Aetherion for twenty-two years. He believes you are dead."

"When do we leave?"

Seraphyne almost smiled. "At dawn," she said.

CHAPTER SIX

The Guardian's Secret



He did not sleep. He packed instead: two changes of clothes, his green sketchbook, six tubes of paint, and his phone. He packed the phone because some objects are not equipment but anchors.

While he packed, she answered his questions.

"Tell me the full bloodline," he said. "All ten before me. I need to know who I am calling when the State comes."

She told him.

The First Vox: Aeron Vaultis, a builder, chosen from Earth because he could see what things wanted to become. The Second and Third: his daughter and her son, both formidable, both remembered. The Fourth: Lady Nyxora. The greatest in the line's recorded history. A painter, whose perception of the world's fundamental nature exceeded every other Vox before or since.

"And after Nyxora?" he asked.

Here Seraphyne's voice took on the particular quality of someone recounting something genuinely extraordinary. "Nyxora had a granddaughter who had four sons. All four of them — simultaneously, which had never happened before and has never happened since — manifested the Vox power. The Vayrune Core recognized all four at once. The five, sixth, seventh, and eighth Voxs were brothers."

Kael stopped packing.

"Four brothers at the same time."

"Yes. Their story is its own legend — four brothers who each carried the full Voxt power simultaneously, who fought their own corrupted father together. A war that nearly destroyed Drakorum before they ended it." She paused. "When it was over, three of the brothers walked to the Shrine. The fourth continued the bloodline. His great-grandson became the Ninth Voxt. And the Ninth's son is Thaerion — the Tenth."

"So Nyxora is my great-great-great-grandmother. And the four brothers are — what — my great-great-grand uncles? And one is my direct ancestor."

"In the bloodline's terms, yes. All four are in the Record. All four will answer when you call the State."

He thought about the dream — the plateau, the statues, more than he had ever counted before. Now he understood.

At five in the morning, Seraphyne handed him something wrapped in cloth.

"Your mother's," she said. "She asked me to give it to you when you were old enough."

Inside the cloth was a small painting. The size of his palm. On a material between metal and paper. Four planets, connected by rings, surrounding an orb. The exact composition he had been painting for two months. And in the sky of the painting, barely visible, a trail of green light — a flying figure, distant, moving fast.

At the bottom: a signature. Lyrielle.

He held the painting for a long time.

"She was a painter," he said.

"It runs," said Seraphyne. "In the bloodline. From Nyxora."

He looked at the painting his dead mother had made of the world he was about to travel to.

"Okay," he said. "Let's go find my father."

PART TWO

Aetherion

CHAPTER SEVEN

Through the Ring Gate

Aetherion System — Planet Elysia



Nothing in his life had prepared him for the view through the portal as it opened.

The Ring Gate was a permanent installation in Midway City's port district — a space Seraphyne had been maintaining for twenty-two years. The Gate itself looked, until activated, like a structural arch of dark metal approximately four meters tall. When she engaged it, the interior filled with something that was not light and not darkness but the specific visual quality of a space showing you somewhere else.

Through it: Aetherion.

He stepped through.

The sky above him was a deep indigo — too many light sources, each slightly wrong in color. Three of the four planets were visible from Elysia's surface as distinct spheres. And at the center of all of them, equidistant from every planet, the Vayrune Core.

He stopped walking.

The Core pulsed with a rhythm that his body responded to before his mind could: his chest tightened, his eyes warmed, the warmth in his hands spiked and settled. He felt two presences — vast and patient and aware — acknowledging him. And his feet left the ground.

Not intentionally. His body simply rose, a few centimeters, in response to the recognition from the Core. He hovered there, slightly above the Elysiar surface, for a full three seconds before he noticed and came back down.

Seraphyne said nothing. She had been expecting this.

"They're in there," he said. "Oryth and Vexul. I can feel them."

"They know you're here. When you cross into Aetherion space, the Core responds to the bloodline. Ten generations of response have made the recognition immediate."

He looked at the Core, green and violet, endlessly moving.

"Later," he said quietly, to the two presences at the edge of his awareness. "I will come and speak to you properly. But I need to find my father first."

The Core's pulse changed — briefly, unmistakably warmer.

He followed Seraphyne toward the city of Elysiar. He did not fly — not yet, not here, in this city he had never visited, where he wanted to walk and see and take it in properly. But the temptation was present every step, and it was pleasant.



The city was built in a style that had no Earth equivalent but which his painter's eye catalogued immediately with the specific pleasure of visual information never encountered before. The buildings were pale stone veined with green-violet energy, and they curved — not arbitrarily but with the logic of flow, buildings responding to their environment the way living things respond. The towers tilted slowly toward the Core's light the way plants tilt toward the sun. The streets were wide and arranged in patterns that felt intuitive at ground level and that, from any elevated position — and he found

himself hovering unconsciously at intersections just to see — resolved into something that looked like language.

He was going to need many more sketchbooks.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Four Worlds



The Council of Elysiar met him in the Arkatheon — the great circular chamber built at the point where the Weave Ring entered Elysiar's surface, its floor a meter of engineered crystal over the Ring itself, so that if you looked down you could see the Ring's energy pulsing in its channel below your feet.

Twelve Councillors from all four planets. The Theronis representatives had the compact precision of career military. The Lyxara scholars wore their seniority in the depth of their eyes. Drakorum's representatives had the permanent focus of people whose work involved ongoing controlled combustion. And the Elysiar Councillors had the look of people who had been managing something enormous for a long time.

"Kael Veyrin," said Ark-Speaker Draveth. "Son of Thaerion Veyrin, the Tenth Voxt, and the late Queen Lyrielle of Elysiar. You are the Eleventh Voxt. The bloodline has been confirmed through the Vayrune Core's response to your arrival."

The room was very quiet.

"The four worlds," said Kael. "Tell me about them. I want to understand the place I am supposed to protect."

Archivist Orvyn — an ancient scholar of Lyxara whose age he could not estimate — made a sound close to approval.

So they told him. Theronis: the military world, where sky fleets were built and soldier academies trained the system's defenders. Its floating fortresses were the most dramatic

feature — entire military installations suspended by the planet's unique magnetic field, mobile and self-sufficient. Lyxara: the academic and spiritual center, where great libraries held the accumulated knowledge of Aetherion's history including the complete Record of the Voxt. Drakorum: the forge world, volcanic and industrial, where the most advanced weapons and armor in the system were made — including the Voxt armor, forged from a material that resonated with the bloodline's energy signature and strengthened in proportion to the wearer's power. And Elysiar: the royal seat, the council center, the location of the Shrine of Stone.

"The Shrine," he said.

"Where the Voxts go," said Archivist Orvyn, "when they choose to end. They perform the Final Conjuring. They become indestructible stone. Their souls join the Record and remain accessible to the current Voxt through Spirit Echoes — and physically present in the Shrine, where their statues radiate the warmth of the still-living soul within." She paused. "There are ten statues in the Shrine now. One for each Voxt who came before you."

"Including the four brothers."

"Including three of the four brothers — the one who continued the bloodline walked to the Shrine as well, after his great-grandchildren were grown. All four brothers are in the Shrine."

Kael thought about the dream. The plateau. The many statues he had walked among.

"And Nyxora — she foresaw me."

"She foresaw a painter," said Orvyn. "She said the greatest Voxt to come would be a painter. She said the State in their hands would reach further than any State before. She left her prophecy in the Record and then walked to the Shrine, and has been waiting

ever since." She looked at him over the Record's page. "She has been waiting quite some time."

"Where is my father?"

CHAPTER NINE

The Statues of the Fallen



They took him to the Shrine the afternoon of his first day on Elysiar.

The Shrine of Stone was on Elysiar's southern plateau, reached by a road worn smooth by ten Voxts who had each walked it knowing exactly what they were walking toward. The plateau was high enough that from it you could see the full spread of Elysiar below, and at the correct angle, three of the other four planets on the horizon.

The statues were not arranged formally. They were not in rows. They were positioned the way people position themselves in a room during conversation: slightly toward each other, angled with the body language of engagement. As though at the moment of their Final Conjuring each Voxt had been in the middle of a thought and the stone had caught them mid-expression.

There were ten.

He walked among them slowly.

The stone was extraordinary — warm. A particular warmth that he felt most strongly in his hands when he passed close — the same warmth as his knuckles when he painted, the same warmth as the two voices from the Vayrune Core.

He found Aeron Vaultis first — the First Voxt, posed in the stance of a man examining a structure, head slightly tilted, one hand extended as though measuring something invisible. A builder to the last.

The Second and Third Voxts stood close to each other, their poses complementary, the stone between them carrying the warmth of a conversation that had been going on for centuries.

Then Nyxora.

She was the largest presence on the plateau — not in terms of the statue's physical scale, but in terms of the way the air around her seemed heavier with meaning. Both arms extended, palms up, the expression of a person who has finished something difficult and is turning their attention to the next thing, which in her case was eternity.

He stood in front of her for a long time.

He put his hand on her extended palm.

The warmth was immediate and specific: a presence, focused, regarding him with the interest of someone who has been waiting for a very long time and has not grown impatient but more certain.

"I know," he said, not aloud, in the way you communicate with something that does not need words. "I know you saw me coming. I'm here."

The warmth pulsed once. Recognition. Welcome.

He moved on and found the four brothers.

They were grouped together — not touching but close, the way four people stand when they have been through something together that no one else can fully understand. The eldest had a warrior's pose, weight forward, head up. The second carried the look of a strategist, eyes in the middle distance. The third was posed mid-stride, still going somewhere even in stone. And the fourth — the one whose bloodline had continued,

his direct ancestor — stood with his arms slightly out from his sides, palms open, the posture of someone who has decided to receive whatever comes next.

Kael stood in front of that fourth brother for a long time.

The warmth from that statue was different from the others — more personal, more immediate, as though the distance between them was not simply time but something thinner.

"Great-great-great-great-grandfather," he said quietly. "That's a lot of greats."

The warmth in the statue's palms pulsed. It felt, distinctly, like amusement.

He found the Ninth Voxt — his great-grandfather — and then his grandfather, the generation between. Then the blank space on the plateau where the tenth statue would eventually go. His father's place. Not yet occupied. Not yet.

He breathed.

Ten presences behind him, warm and patient. Waiting to be called.

"Let's go find my father," he said to Seraphyne.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Crimson Infection



He spent twelve days on Aetherion before the war came, and he used them.

Training with Seraphyne — without excess, with total precision. He learned the scope of his Conjuring: at first, objects to the mass of a vehicle; by day five, sections of the Elysian training ground wall, three meters of stone lifted and relocated without cracking. He learned Astral Reinforcement by practicing on Seraphyne herself, his field extending to her with the quality of the power when it worked correctly: not forced but offered and accepted.

He learned to fly properly.

This was the part of training that required the least instruction and the most adjustment — not learning how, but learning to stop overthinking it. The power was intuitive. The first time he went to full speed over the Elysian plains he covered what Seraphyne estimated was forty kilometers in under twenty seconds, reversed course without slowing, and came back so fast he nearly overshot the training ground entirely. He learned control. He learned the difference between combat speed, which was explosive and directional, and patrol speed, which was sustained and precise. He learned that in the air he could form the circular constructs differently than on the ground — rings that moved with him, platforms that held solid under weight, shields that rotated around his body like orbit.

He also learned what he was fighting.

Malzareth — the Crimson Soul King — was a corruption. Made by gods who feared the Soul Emperors' choice. A being fueled by consumed souls, who grew more powerful with every will he overrode. He could split fragments of his dark soul-energy into other beings and rewrite them — not by force but by slow infection. The red eyes were the last stage. By the time the eyes showed red, the person was gone.

"How do you reverse it?" Kael asked.

"The Voxt Conjuring field disrupts the soul-bond," Seraphyne said. "It introduces clear signal — a perception of true reality that the infection cannot suppress. Within the field's range, infected individuals experience a restoration of their own will. They can choose." A pause. "Most choose themselves."

"And Malzareth himself?"

"The source has never been directly defeated. The Voxt State is the only power in this system capable of reaching him at his depth." She looked at him. "And in your hands, with all ten predecessors manifesting — it will reach further than it has ever reached."

Kael thought about Nyxora's prophecy. The storm that had finally found a sky large enough.

"Then we'd better make sure the storm is ready," he said.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Council Wars



On the eighth day, the Three Siblings made their first open move.

Thirty-seven members of Lyxara's governing body were found to be compromised in a single morning — Sylthera's infection network activated all at once, their red-tinted eyes visible in the Council chamber when the infected moved simultaneously to seize the building's communication infrastructure. A Theronis military attachment contained the incident, but the signal it sent was impossible to ignore.

The war was beginning. Before any of them were entirely ready.

Kael stood in the emergency session of the combined Council — not as a Councillor but as the Vox. A different kind of presence. Structural rather than political.

He listened. He catalogued. He looked for the load-bearing points.

At the end of the session, when Ark-Speaker Draveth asked for his assessment, Kael gave it plainly: "They are forcing our response before we are ready. Sylthera wants the Council system destabilized so that Vorakh's military force arrives into a command vacuum. We cannot prevent the attack. We can ensure the command structure is not the casualty." He looked around the chamber. "Every Councillor in this room should be tested for infection before leaving today. Every decision made in the next thirty days should be made from hardened positions outside the known Council infrastructure. And I need the Ring Gates locked to authorized transit only, immediately."

The Council moved.

Thaerion caught his eye from across the chamber and gave him a look that was brief and complete and said: good.

Kael looked back and thought: I learned from the best bloodline in the system.

He rose a few inches off the floor when he was not paying attention and had to consciously come back down. He was going to have to work on that.

PART THREE

The Return of Darkness

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Three Siblings Return



They came at dawn on the fifteenth day.

Vorakh had always had a dramatist's instinct, and there was something in the way the Vayrune Core's light caught the Weave Rings at the moment of the system's dawn that made every entrance more significant. He came as a statement.

The signal reached Elysiar first: a catastrophic energy discharge over Theronis. Vorakh's destruction magic, at full extension, applied to the three largest floating fortresses above the planet's northern hemisphere. The fortresses listed. Their power systems flickered. Across Theronis, alarms that had not sounded in twenty-two years sounded simultaneously.

The war was no longer a war of preparation.

Kael was in the training ground when the alarm reached Elysiar. He stopped. He looked at Seraphyne.

"Theronis," she said. Her voice had shifted into the register she used when events had overtaken planning.

"We go," he said.

"You have had fifteen days."

"I know." He looked at his hands. Steady. Warm. Present. "It will have to be enough."

The Ring Gate to Theronis opened in forty seconds. They went through.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Fall of Theronis

Planet Theronis



The sky above Theronis was wrong.

A deep, churning red at the horizon, spreading — not weather but power. Vorakh's signature. The destruction magic had a color, and the color was the precise red of something old and certain and consumed by its own certainty.

The three floating fortresses above the northern hemisphere were still aloft but damaged: structural members visible where the destruction magic had opened them, energy systems sparking, defensive arrays going in and out.

Kael came through the Ring Gate and did not wait to assess from the ground.

He rose immediately — straight up, fast, forty meters into the air above the Ring Gate platform — and looked out at the full scope of the battlefield from above. His Conjuring field opened naturally at altitude, its range extending in all directions. From up here he could see what the ground view would have made impossible: the true geometry of the attack, the positions of the soul-infected advance forces, the structural damage to each fortress, the load-bearing points of the entire situation.

"The fortresses," he called down to Seraphyne, who was coordinating on the ground with a Theronis commander. "I can hold them from here. All three."

He extended both hands — level with his shoulders, palms up — and felt the three fortresses in their damaged state. The handle of a damaged thing is its remaining

integrity: what is still whole, what still wants to hold. He Conjured the three fortresses into cooperation simultaneously, asking their remaining structure to support itself more fully. Three broad rings of green energy formed around each fortress, circling slowly, anchoring the structural field.

The metal groaned. Stabilized. Held.

On the ground and on the fortress decks, Theronis soldiers paused and looked up. Then resumed, faster. Because the fortresses were holding.

"How long can you maintain that?" Seraphyne called up.

"Long enough," he called back. "Find Vorakh."

He did not need her to find Vorakh. He was already moving toward the red light on the horizon — rising higher, accelerating, the air parting around him with the specific quality of something built for this — flying toward the war at a speed that closed the distance before he had finished the thought of going.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Breaking of the Rings



The Three Siblings had a strategy: remove the Voxt's tools.

The Weave Rings were the structural logic of Aetherion. Without them, Aetherion was four isolated planets. Without them, the Ring Gates were impossible. Without them, the Voxt's ability to move between worlds at speed was eliminated.

Kaedros had been working toward this for three years. He had identified seven points in the Ring system whose simultaneous disruption would cause a cascade failure.

He hit all seven simultaneously.

Kael felt it before the instruments reported it — felt it the way you feel when something structural changes. Across Aetherion, the Weave Rings flickered. One section above Lyxara went dark. The Ring Gate network destabilized.

The four planets were cut off from each other.

Kael was in the air above the Theronis northern city when it happened. He stopped — hovering at altitude, the damaged fortresses stable in their green anchor rings below — and assessed.

Seraphyne's voice came through his comm. "They've split us. Thaerion is on Elysiar. Your sister is on Elysiar."

"The Ring is disrupted," Kael said. "Not destroyed. The energy is still there — it has just been interrupted." He was already feeling for it — reaching out with the Conjuring sense, finding the Weave Ring's presence in the sky around Theronis, tracing its energy

to the interference points. "The Ring knows what it is supposed to do. It has been doing it for millennia. I just need to ask it to remember."

"No Voxt has ever Conjured a Weave Ring," Seraphyne said from below.

"Nyxora said the next great Voxt would reach further than any before." He paused. "I choose to believe her."

He closed his eyes. At altitude, hovering perfectly still, he reached.



The Ring was vast — an infrastructure of cosmic engineering spanning the distance between worlds — and its structural logic was orders of magnitude more complex than anything he had worked with before. He felt for its handle the way you feel for something in the dark: slowly, with full attention, without forcing.

He found it.

The Ring wanted to flow. That was its nature. Kaedros had introduced interruptions at seven points, and the energy was pooling behind them, looking for direction. The handle was the energy's own intention. He did not repair the interference. He asked the energy to route around it — the way water routes around a boulder, finding new channels through the Ring's secondary pathways that had never been used but had always been there.

Around his hovering body, green circle-constructs formed — large ones, several meters across, stacked at different angles, spinning slowly. Each ring aligned with one of the seven disrupted Ring points, acting as a focusing structure for the Conjuring, concentrating his intention precisely where it was needed.

The Weave Ring shuddered.

Then it lit.

Not fully — the damaged sections remained damaged — but enough. The primary pathway reopened. The Ring Gate network reconnected on backup channels. Across Aetherion, the transit indicators shifted from impossible to emergency capacity.

Kael opened his eyes. His hands were bright green and he was breathing harder than usual. The circle-constructs faded slowly, one by one.

"Get Thaerion on the comm," he called down. "Tell him the Ring is back. Tell him we need everyone here."

He rose higher and turned back toward the advancing army. There was work to do.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Death March



The Three Siblings arrived at Theronis with their full force on the third day.

The army was larger than anything Kael had been briefed on. The soul-infected moved in the synchronized way he had seen on Earth, but here at the scale of full military formation the effect was philosophically overwhelming. Thousands of beings who had each been a person, now moving as a single organism.

Vorakh led the northern advance. Sylthera had no visible position in the march, which was more frightening than if she had led it. Kaedros led the eastern flank with the precise geometric efficiency of a born military commander.

Kael fought from the air.

He did not fight like an infantry unit — did not hold ground, did not form a line. He moved across the battlefield the way a painter's eye moves across a canvas: taking in the whole, identifying the critical points, acting precisely where the action mattered most. He was at the northern front one moment, his Conjuring field extending to disrupt the soul-infected advance, the infected soldiers' red eyes flickering as the clear signal reached them — and then he was at the eastern flank two seconds later, having crossed the entire battlefield at speed, arriving in time to intercept a flanking formation with a wall of stacked green ring-constructs that the formation broke against like a wave.

He could feel the soul-infected within his field's range. Each one a handle. He did not try to free them individually — there were too many, and the complete liberation required something larger. He disrupted. He slowed. He turned unified movements

into confused ones. He made the city itself a tool, Conjuring structural elements into positions that funneled the advance, changed the battlefield's geometry, made the army's mathematical advantage into something it could not fully use.

Seraphyne coordinated the Theronis military on the ground with the efficiency of the best work of her career.

And on the fourth hour, Thaerion arrived through the emergency Ring Gate.

He came through at speed — rising immediately, not stopping, ascending to altitude and meeting Kael in the air above the battlefield with the specific controlled urgency of a man who had been waiting for his signal and was ready the moment it came. In the air, hovering beside his son for the first time, Thaerion looked at Kael with an expression that Kael would not find words for until much later. Something between recognition and relief. Two people built for the same sky, finally in it together.

The bloodline resonance doubled the moment they were airborne together. Kael's field range expanded. His constructs grew brighter, more defined. The handles of every element in the battlefield sharpened.

"Ready?" Thaerion said.

"Been ready," Kael said.

They split to cover both flanks simultaneously, moving at speeds that left green trails of light across the Theronis sky — two streaks of fire, coordinated without speaking, reading the battlefield with the same inherited perception.

Father and son. Tenth and Eleventh. Flying.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Last Shrine



Sylthera's move came on the fifth hour.

She had not been at the battle. She had been on Elysiar.

The report came from Princess Elyra — Kael's younger sister, whom he had met six days ago and who had absorbed twenty-two years of missed sibling history with the equanimity of someone whose spiritual gifts included an extraordinary ability to identify what was essential and act on it: Sylthera had reached the Shrine of Stone with twenty soul-infected soldiers and was attacking the statues — not physically, but with the infection. Attempting to sever the connection between the living Voxt and the ten ancestral souls in the Record.

If she succeeded, the Voxt State was gone.

Kael felt it the moment it began — felt it as a disruption in the warmth of the ten presences he had come to know as constants, like interference turned up between him and a signal he had been receiving clearly.

"The Shrine," he said. To Thaerion, in the air beside him.

"Go," said Thaerion immediately. "I hold here."

"The field —"

"Leave it with me. Go. They are your ancestors. All ten of them." Thaerion met his eyes in the air, hovering, the green-violet fire of his own power steady in his gaze. "None of them waited this long to be lost to Sylthera."

Kael went. He did not take the Ring Gate. He rose to altitude, turned toward Elysiar's position in the sky, and found the emergency Ring Gate entry point — and then he was through and above Elysiar and descending toward the southern plateau in a controlled dive that covered the distance to the Shrine in seconds.

Elyra was at the plateau's edge. "She is at Nyxora's statue," she said, already moving.

Of course she was.



The plateau at night was lit by the Vayrune Core's ambient light — a green-violet wash across the stone. Sylthera stood at the center of the Shrine before Nyxora's statue, her hands extended, red light seeping from her palms into the stone. Not violence but patience. The corruption technique, applied to something it had never before been applied to: a Voxt's preserved soul.

The stone was resisting. He could see it — the warmth in the stone fighting the red intrusion, the green-violet energy of the bloodline pushing back against the corruption. Nyxora, fighting from the stone. Ten of them, in fact — across the plateau, all ten statues were engaged, their ambient warmth turned active, a system-wide resistance that Sylthera was pushing against and that was, slowly, losing ground.

Kael landed at the Shrine's entrance. He did not rush. He walked.

"Stop," he said.

Sylthera looked at him. Her eyes were her own — dark and calculating.

"The painter," she said. "You are newer than I expected."

"Take your hands off my ancestors," he said.

"They are stone," she said. "They cannot be harmed."

"They are not stone," he said. "And they are telling me, right now, that you are losing."

He looked at the statues around him — all ten, warm, present, fighting. "You are outnumbered ten to one. And they have been here longer than you have been doing this."

He extended his field.

On Elysiar, without the compound effect of his father's proximity, his individual maximum — but with the ten statues actively contributing, adding their warmth to his field, the Shrine itself becoming an amplifier for the Conjuring — the field extended to its largest single radius yet. The red light retreated from Nyxora's statue in one clean wave. Across the plateau, the infection in seventeen of the twenty soul-infected soldiers cleared simultaneously, red leaving their eyes, the people returning to themselves.

Elyra handled the remaining three with the authority of someone whose spiritual connection to the Shrine had just been confirmed as considerably more powerful than she had previously tested.

Sylthera withdrew from the engagement. She looked at Kael one final time.

"You are closer to the State than you know," she said. It sounded like a threat. It also sounded like a warning. "When it comes — painter — it will be bigger than you expect. Even you will be surprised."

Then she was gone.

Kael stood in the Shrine. He walked to Nyxora's statue and placed his hand on her extended palm.

The warmth was very bright — more active, more present than any previous visit. Not retreating. Leaning in.

"I know," he said. "Soon."

He looked across the plateau at all ten statues — Aeron the builder, the Second and Third, Nyxora, the four brothers grouped together, the Ninth, and his grandfather. Ten souls. Ten lives of accumulated power. Waiting.

"I will not waste it," he said. To all of them.

The warmth of the entire plateau pulsed once, all ten statues simultaneously.

They knew.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Awakening of Vox



He went back to Theronis and found the battle in its seventh hour, his father holding the field in the air above the northern city — maintaining both their fields by bloodline resonance alone, the effort of it visible in the set of his shoulders and the slight laboring of his flight path, no longer the precise controlled movement of a man at ease but the trajectory of someone burning the last of a considerable reserve.

Vorakh had found him.

The eldest Sibling was in the air too — rising to meet Thaerion at altitude, his destruction magic extended to a sphere of red-dark energy that dismantled anything within its radius. Buildings below the sphere's edge became structureless. Energy became incoherent. Soldiers on the ground lost coherence and fell into confusion.

And Thaerion was fighting the edge of it — his own field pressed up against the sphere's boundary, holding it back, buying space for the ground forces below. His armor was cracked at the shoulder. His left arm was held at the wrong angle. His flight path dipped and corrected and dipped again.

Kael came through the Ring Gate and rose immediately.

He covered the distance to the aerial engagement in three seconds, arriving beside his father at altitude, the bloodline resonance snapping back into compound effect the moment they were proximate. Thaerion's flight path steadied.

"Good timing," Thaerion said. Blood on the left side of his face.

"Always," Kael said.

Vorakh looked at him across the air between them. His destruction sphere rotated slowly, maintained at distance from both Voxts.

"The painter," Vorakh said. His voice had the quality of something very old and very certain and very wrong about the certainty. "How many times will you make me say that word?"

"Until it stops sounding like an insult," Kael said.

Vorakh sent the sphere at them.

What followed was an aerial engagement unlike anything in Aetherion's recorded history — two Voxts and an ancient conqueror, fighting in the air above a burning city, moving at speeds that left visible trails of light in the sky. Thaerion drew Vorakh's attention, pressing his own Voxt field against the sphere's edge at close range, working the structural logic of the destruction energy the way a craftsman works resistant material — carefully, precisely, looking for the point of cooperation. Kael worked at range — flying fast, approaching from angles Vorakh could not cover, throwing circle-constructs large enough to encompass significant portions of the sphere and hold its boundaries, slowing its expansion, preventing it from growing.

They could not collapse it. Not together, not yet. The sphere was Vorakh's core power — centuries of refinement, his fundamental expression — and it did not have a simple handle.

But they could contain it. And while they contained it, Sael arrived from the eastern flank.

Sael Vek, the younger brother of the Three Siblings, had the specific tactical gift of identifying the moment a battle changed and acting on it before anyone else had

processed the change. He saw two Voxts in aerial engagement with Vorakh and immediately identified the variable he could address: Kael was the less experienced combatant, the one whose aerial patterns were still developing, the one who was thinking while he flew rather than flying from pure instinct.

He attacked Kael's flight path — not directly, but structurally, using ranged destruction magic to alter the terrain Kael was navigating, removing the reference points that an instinctive flyer uses without knowing they are using them. Kael banked left and found the architecture he expected had been dismantled. Banked right and found the same. He adjusted, adjusted again, and on the third adjustment Sael hit him.

Not a kill shot. Sael was too careful for kill shots when the math was unclear. But a significant impact — a concentrated blast of red-dark energy that hit Kael's Conjuring field from an angle the field did not cover and drove him out of the sky.

He fell.

Forty meters. The impact with the Theronis street below would have been catastrophic if the field had not partially reactivated on the way down, slowing him — but it was not a controlled landing. He hit the street and the street cracked under him and he lay there, on his back, looking up at the burning Theronis sky, and everything was quiet for a moment.

Two broken ribs. He could feel them. The field had taken the worst of it but not all.

In the sky above him, his father was alone against Vorakh now. The sphere was expanding. The battle's edge was collapsing toward the populated areas.

Kael lay on the broken street.

He thought about the Shrine. About ten statues, all pulsing once, all at once. They knew.

He thought about Nyxora. The ocean she had stopped. The storm finding a sky large enough. The ten predecessors who had been waiting to be called.

He thought about his mother's hand on his forehead. Green light moving across his skin. One day, you will become more powerful than all of us.

He thought about the words. The words he had known since Seraphyne said them in the safehouse and felt the key enter the lock.

And then he laughed.

Not hysterically. Not desperately. He laughed the way you laugh when something that has been complicated for a very long time suddenly becomes very simple. Lying on a broken street in the middle of a war, two cracked ribs, the sky on fire above him, and he laughed.

He sat up.

He stood up.

He rose into the air — slowly, deliberately, not the explosive launch of combat but the deliberate ascent of someone who has decided something — and he rose until he was at the same altitude as his father, and he looked at Vorakh's sphere, and he found the handle of it the way Nyxora had taught him through her page in the Record: not by looking at the surface of the thing but by looking at the thing behind the thing.

The sphere's nature: energy taught to dismantle. Energy that had lost its original direction. Energy that was, at its root, the same cosmic substance as the Weave Rings and the Vayrune Core and the Vox power — the same source, redirected into corruption.

He found the load-bearing point of that corruption.

He took a breath.

And he said it.

"By the power of Vext."

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Father and Son



The sound came first.

A rapid wave — a thrust of displaced energy that moved outward from Kael's body in all directions simultaneously, a soundwave and a shockwave and something that had no name in physics but that every soul on every planet in the Aetherion system felt at the same moment: a pulse, like a second heartbeat, like something that had been waiting in the cosmic architecture of the system and had finally been given permission to move.

The soul-infected on the ground below stopped where they stood. The Theronis soldiers stopped. Seraphyne stopped. Even Vorakh, in the air, paused — and Vorakh did not pause for anything.

Because emerging from Kael's body, rising from him and floating outward to surround him in the air, visible to every eye that looked at the sky above the northern city of Theronis, were the ten Voxts.

Not as people. Not as solid figures. As presences given light — each one distinct, each one recognizable if you knew their history. Aeron Vaultis, the builder, his form patient and observant. The Second and Third Voxts, close to each other as they had been in the Shrine. Lady Nyxora — the largest presence, the most luminous, her arms extended in the pose she had chosen for her Final Conjuring, her painted light blazing green. The four brothers: Draven, Sorek, Cael, and Miran — four distinct energies, each with its own quality, Draven fierce, Sorek measured, Cael kinetic, Miran open, all four

surrounding Kael with the warmth of ancestors who had been waiting for this specific moment. The Ninth and the grandfather-Voxt, completing the circle.

Ten spirits, floating in the air around the eleventh.

Visible to everyone.

Kael's eyes blazed — green at the core, violet at the edge, the full Voxt State, and the eyes of every spirit around him blazed with the same light, a constellation of Voxt fire above the burning city.

He looked at Vorakh's sphere.

And he found its handle.



He did not fight the sphere directly. He Conjured it — asked the energy within it to remember what it was before the corruption, before centuries of misdirection, before someone decided that the fundamental substance of the universe was best used to dismantle rather than to build. He asked it to return to coherence the way he had asked the Weave Ring to return to flow.

But this time, ten predecessors contributed simultaneously. Aeron's architectural perception. Nyxora's painter's scale. The four brothers' combined combat knowledge — four different approaches to the same power, four lifetimes of finding handles. The Ninth's experience. His grandfather's.

The sphere collapsed.

Not explosively. Smoothly, completely, without drama — the energy within it dissipating back into the atmospheric background, and where there had been a zone of structural dismantling there was now simply air. The city below it, which had been

half-crumbling, stabilized. The structural logic of Theronis's northern district reasserted itself.

Thaerion looked at his son.

He looked at the ten spirits surrounding him.

He looked at Vorakh, who had taken his first step backward in twenty-two years.

Thaerion's Voxt State engaged — eyes blazing, his own power at full extension — and the compound effect of two Voxts, one in full State with ten predecessors manifesting, was something that had never existed before in the history of the bloodline. The field expanded to cover the entire northern city. Every soul-infected soldier within it was simultaneously offered clear signal. The red retreated from ten thousand pairs of eyes at once.

The army woke up.

"This," said Kael — and his voice in the Voxt State carried the resonance of eleven generations speaking at once, each one still individually him, still recognizably Kael Veyrin the painter from Caldwell District, but with the depth of everything that had led to him present in every word — "is over."

Vorakh said nothing for a long moment.

Then: "The painter." One last time. And now the word was not dismissal. It was acknowledgment.

He withdrew.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Soul War



Vorakh did not surrender. Beings of that age and certainty do not surrender. They withdraw and they plan and they return. But he withdrew, and in the space of that withdrawal all three Siblings converged — Kaedros from the eastern flank, Sylthera returning from Elysiar — all three together in the air above the battlefield, facing two Voxts and ten manifesting ancestral spirits.

What followed was not beautiful. It was real, physical and cosmic simultaneously, and costly. Thaerion's injuries — broken arm fought through for seven hours, wounds from sustained exposure to Vorakh's sphere — were real injuries that the Voxt State ignored rather than healed. Kael's ribs were still cracked. Neither of them stopped.

They fought in the air.

Kael moved with a speed and precision that had not been available to him before the State — ten predecessors' combined aerial experience, including four brothers who had fought a war in the skies above Drakorum, informing every turn, every approach angle, every moment of acceleration. He was still himself — still Kael, still the painter who read compositions — but he was also Nyxora reading the battlefield as a canvas, Draven pushing into the center with the warrior's instinct for the decisive moment, Miran holding his ground with his arms open and his field active, receiving whatever came at him without flinching.

The ten spirits moved with him. They did not fight independently — they were extensions of him, not separate agents — but their forms moved in his wake as he flew,

illuminating his path with ten colors of the same green-violet fire, and the visual effect of the Eleventh Vext crossing the battlefield at speed with ten predecessor-spirits trailing behind him like a comet's tail of living light was, by every account gathered afterward, the most extraordinary thing anyone who witnessed it had ever seen.

Seraphyne, on the ground, watching him cross the battlefield for the seventh time, made a note in her operational record that she later did not show anyone because it said only: exactly as promised.

The battle took six hours.

At the end of it, the Three Siblings withdrew. Not defeated in the absolute sense — not destroyed, not captured. But their army was gone: liberated, the soul-infected returning to themselves across the field. Their aerial superiority was gone. Their strategic position was gone. And the painter they had called small was standing in the burning sky above Theronis with ten ancestors at his back and eyes that blazed with the light of eleven generations.

Vorakh looked at him one final time before disappearing.

He said nothing. Then he was gone.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Green and Violet Storm



Malzareth came when the Three Siblings fell back.

He came because two Voxts in compound State, with ten predecessors manifesting, was a signal he could not ignore. He came because Kael's Conjuring of the Weave Ring had told him something about the Eleventh Vext he had not been willing to believe: the prophecy was true. All of it. Including the part about reach.

He came as what he was: not a body, not a figure with a face. A presence — massive, dark, consuming — entering Theronis's atmosphere as a pressure wave and manifesting as a field of Crimson Soul infection so intense and concentrated that the air darkened. The liberated soul-infected on the ground flickered. Some held. Some did not. The infection was an ocean and Malzareth at full presence was the tide.

Kael was still in the air, the Vext State still active, the ten spirits still manifesting around him, when he felt the Crimson Soul King arrive.

He turned his full perception on Malzareth and looked at his nature the way Nyxora had taught him — the painter's looking, the looking that goes past the surface to the thing behind the thing.

He saw it.

Malzareth was fear.

Not the product of fear — fear itself, condensed and weaponized and turned outward across centuries. The gods who made him had taken the fear of losing connection, the

fear of being alone in an indifferent universe, and made it into a being. And the being had, over centuries, fed that fear into everyone it touched, because the only thing fear wants is company.

At Kael's side, Nyxora's spirit blazed brighter. She had seen this. She had described it in the prophecy: the end of something is also the beginning.

The handle of Malzareth's power was his own nature.

Thaerion rose to altitude beside him — his own State fully engaged, eyes blazing, his injuries ignored — and did not speak. He had been fighting this for twenty-two years. He had been waiting for this moment, the moment when it could be ended properly, for twenty-two years. He looked at his son. He was ready.

Kael was ready.

They flew at Malzareth's presence simultaneously — two Voxts in compound State, ten manifesting spirits, the combined power of eleven generations directed at the load-bearing point of the Crimson Soul King's nature.

It was the largest Conjuring any Voxt had ever performed.

Kael did not destroy Malzareth — the Crimson Soul King was too old and too fundamental for destruction. He Conjured him: asked the energy within him to remember what it was before it was corrupted. Asked the fear within him to return to its source. Asked the terrible consuming loneliness that had been made into a weapon to simply be what it was — loneliness, not a king, not a conqueror, not a god.

The ten predecessor-spirits contributed simultaneously, each adding the specific quality of their Voxt power to the Conjuring. Aeron's foundation. Nyxora's scale. The four brothers' combined force. The full accumulated weight of eleven generations directed at one point.

The sky above Theronis turned green and violet.

Both colors simultaneously. Vast and complete and visible from the farthest inhabited point in the Aetherion system.

And Malzareth contracted.

Not eliminated. Compressed — pushed back into the boundaries the First Voxt had established and that every subsequent Voxt had maintained, but this time the compression went further than it had ever gone before. The Eleventh Voxt and the Tenth, together, in compound State with the full manifesting weight of ten predecessors, pushed the Crimson Soul King back to a depth of containment that had not been achieved in the history of the bloodline.

When it was over, the sky was clear.

The infection on every soul-infected soldier in Theronis released simultaneously.

The battle was over.

The ten spirits receded gradually — not vanishing, not going anywhere, simply becoming less externally visible and more internally present, returning to the depth of the bloodline where they lived. Miran was the last to recede, and before he did he held for a moment, his presence warm and particular, and the feeling of it was the same as touching his statue on the plateau: amusement, warmth, and a satisfaction that had been a very long time coming.

Kael released the Voxt State.

He was still in the air. He landed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Final Stand



Thaerion went down when the State released.

He held himself airborne for thirty seconds after — by the will of a man who would not permit himself to go down while there was still something to assess. He looked at the battlefield. The Three Siblings gone. The soul-infected released. The Theronis military beginning the enormous practical work of aftermath. The four planets reconnected through the Weave Ring backup channels he had established.

He looked at his son.

"Good work," he said.

Then his flight faltered and he fell — not far, eight or nine meters, a controlled descent that became an uncontrolled one at the last moment — and Seraphyne caught him before he hit the ground with the reflexes of someone who had been watching his biometrics for the last forty seconds and knew exactly when it was coming.

The injuries were real and extensive: the broken arm fought through for seven hours; deep bruising across the chest from sustained exposure to Vorakh's destruction sphere; the physiological cost of holding two Vext fields simultaneously for seven hours, which no medical text had a protocol for because no one had ever done it before. And the specific cost of the compound State — two living Vexts in simultaneous State, with one of them also maintaining ten manifesting predecessor-spirits — was something the Lyxaran healers would be writing about for decades.

He was not going to die. They were clear about that.

But he was going to rest, and rest was going to mean weeks rather than days.

Kael sat beside his father on the field, on the ground, while the world organized itself around them. He held Thaerion's good hand. Thaerion's eyes were closed. His breathing was steady.

The Vayrune Core pulsed in the sky above Theronis. Green and violet. Familiar now.

"I have you," Kael said quietly. "Rest."



In the days that followed, the structure of what had happened settled into clarity.

The Three Siblings had withdrawn to an unknown position. They were not gone — Sylthera's networks remained partially operational, Vorakh's destruction magic was undiminished, Kaedros had retreated in good order. They would rebuild. They would return.

But they had lost this engagement comprehensively. The soul-infected army was liberated. The Weave Rings were damaged but not broken — Kael's emergency Conjuring had held. The Council structure was intact. And Malzareth's containment was deeper than it had been since the First Voxt established it.

The Vayrune Core was brighter than it had been in three generations. Oryth and Vexul spoke to Kael.

They did not say much. They were not beings who said more than was necessary.

What they said was: We chose correctly.

"I know," he said. "But I had help."

He felt something that was, in beings of that age and nature, the equivalent of amusement.

That, they said, is what we chose correctly.

On the plateau of Elysiar, the ten statues pulsed once, all together, at the same moment.

Then they settled back to their ordinary warmth.

Still present. Always present.

EPILOGUE

The Hero of Earth

Midway City



The suit was Drakorum's work.

The weapons guild on the forge world had been working on it for three days while the battle was fought. Seraphyne had commissioned it before they left Elysiar the first time, with the specific forward-planning quality that made her extraordinary, because she had known that sooner or later the Eleventh Voxt would need armor that could hold his field without degrading and survive the specific stresses of sustained high-speed flight.

The material was Drakorum-forged — a composite that resonated with the Voxt energy signature and strengthened proportionally to the wearer's power. The color was deep black with an undertone that shifted toward green-violet at certain angles, most visible at the seams and joints where the field's energy bled through. The suit was built to handle flight: streamlined at the shoulders, reinforced at the forearms where the circular constructs were most frequently generated, with surfaces that did not resist speed but negotiated with it.

At the chest, at Kael's request, the guild's makers had embedded a design: a brushstroke pattern, abstract, rendered in green-violet energy and sealed permanently into the suit's surface.

He had painted the design himself. Of course he had.

He put it on in the hangar and rose a few inches off the floor to test the suit's response to flight. It responded well — the energy distribution was even, the field extension natural. He came back down and looked at himself in the ship's polished hull.

He was still recognizably himself: twenty-two years old, paint-stained hands visible below the suit's gauntlets because he had not yet put the gauntlets on, the same face that had looked back at him from the bathroom mirror in Midway City with the irises slowly filling with green light and no vocabulary for what that meant.

He had the vocabulary now. He had the suit. He had the sky.

Thaerion was still in medical care, accepting rest with the specific impatience of a person who had been in motion for twenty-two years and did not know what stillness felt like anymore. But he had sent a message through Elyra: "He says the suit looks right. He says come back. He says don't do anything he wouldn't do — which leaves a lot of room. He also says: next time you laugh right before calling the State, maybe do it a little faster."

Kael had laughed at that for a long time.

Elyra stood with him at the hangar entrance. She had accepted the mantle of acting queen of Elysiar with the same equanimity she applied to everything — thoroughly, without ceremony, by simply beginning to do it.

"Come back often," she said.

"Often," he agreed.

"Earth needs you."

"Aetherion needs you," he said. "I think that works out."

Seraphyne was at the ship. She had decided — after considerable internal deliberation — to return to Earth with him. The immediate danger passing was not the same as the danger being resolved, and the Eleventh Voxt returning to Earth alone was not a thing she was willing to permit.

He was glad she was coming.

"There is a signal," she said when they were aboard, reviewing the monitoring equipment she had maintained on Midway City throughout the entire period.

"Different from the Crimson Soul trackers. Older. Something that has been present in Midway City for longer than Malzareth's people. It has not moved while you were here. It is waiting."

"Something on Earth," he said. Not a question.

"Something that has been watching for you. Or watching for this — the moment the bloodline fully activated."

He thought about the agreement the Soul Emperors had made with Earth's powers — the deity Nabu, the cosmic guardians, the forgotten kings of magic — when the Voxt lineage was first established. Protect Aetherion. Protect Earth. He had, in the last month, addressed the first part.

The second was waiting.

"Then let's go find out what it is," he said.

The ship broke atmosphere.

Below, Aetherion turned its slow extraordinary turn: four planets, threaded by Weave Rings, surrounding the Vayrune Core that pulsed green and violet and ancient and alive. On the plateau of Elysiar's southern continent, too small to see from altitude, ten

statues stood warm on the stone of the Shrine. Ten Voxts. Waiting, as they always waited, and present, as they were always present.

He took out his sketchbook.

He started drawing. The Vayrune Core. The Weave Rings. The four planets from above. And in the foreground, rising from the surface of Elysiar, a figure in flight: trailing green light, moving at the speed of something that has finally found the sky it was built for, surrounded by ten smaller lights — ten presences, ten predecessors, moving with him.

He would paint it properly when he got back.

He had the colors now.

Earth waited ahead.

And the Eleventh Voxt — Kael Veyrin, painter, warrior, heir, son, brother, the fulfillment of a prophecy left centuries ago by a woman who had stopped catastrophe and then chosen to become stone — went home.

By the power of Voxt.



End of Book One

The Voxt Chronicles continue in Book Two: The Eleventh Voxt.

A NOTE ON THE CHRONICLES

The Voxt Chronicles is a series built across multiple volumes, each illuminating a distinct chapter of this bloodline.

Book Two: The Eleventh Voxt — Kael's continued story on Earth, as he faces the ancient signal waiting in Midway City and the oncoming threat the Soul Emperors foresaw.

Book Three: Aeron Vaultis — The First Voxt. The man chosen by two emperor-souls and the greatest powers of Earth. The bridge between worlds, and the beginning of everything.

Book Four: Lady Nyxora — The Fourth Voxt. The greatest in the line's history. The painter who stopped catastrophe and left a prophecy that would take centuries to be understood.

Book Five: The Four Brothers — Draven, Sorek, Cael, and Miran. The only time in the Voxt line's history that four members of the bloodline carried the full power simultaneously. Their war against their own corrupted father, and what each of them paid to end it.

Each volume stands on its own. Each is necessary to the whole. Each earns its place in the Chronicles.



— Jason